Chapter Three

The Elephant that Did Not Bark in the Night?

‘A rollicking, erratic, passionate, indelibly human, curiously attractive figure.’[1]

(Arthur Schlesinger on Nikita Khrushchev)

‘An obscene figure … this fat, vulgar man, with his pig eyes and his ceaseless flow of talk.’[2]

(Harold Macmillan on Nikita Khrushchev)

‘Berlin is the West’s balls. Every time I want to make the West scream, I squeeze on Berlin.’[3]

(Nikita Khrushchev)

‘We cannot separate [the] safety [of West Berlin] from our own … we have given our word that an attack upon that city will be regarded as an attack upon us all.’[4]

(John F Kennedy)

Between November 1943 and March 1944 RAF Bomber Command waged a determined if futile bombing offensive against the city of Berlin. It was designed by its commander-in-chief, Air Chief Marshal Sir Arthur Harris, to win the war by destroying the German capital. The United States Eighth Army Air Force refused to become engaged in the offensive, preferring daylight precision attacks against military-industrial